Use well-flavored Cheddar and serve the soup with plenty of warm, crusty bread. Use blue cheese if you prefer, but crumble it rather than try to grate it!

cheddar and chive soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS PLUS REHEATING **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE CRÈME FRAÎCHE

2–3 tbsp of butter
¼ small celeriac, chopped
1 onion, chopped
1 carrot, chopped
1 potato, chopped
3¼ cups vegetable or chicken stock
1 bay leaf
salt and freshly ground black pepper
small handful of fresh chive stalks
⅔ cup milk
4oz (115g) Cheddar cheese, grated
4 tbsp crème fraîche, plus extra to serve

1 Melt the butter in a large saucepan. Add the celeriac, onion, carrot, and potato, and cook gently, stirring, for 2 minutes, or until softened but not browned. Add the stock and bay leaf and season with salt and pepper. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat, cover, and simmer gently for 30 minutes. Remove the bay leaf, purée the soup in a blender or food processor, then return to the rinsed-out pan.

2 Reserving 4 chive stalks for garnish, chop the remainder finely. Add to the soup with the milk, cheese, and crème fraîche. Heat through gently, stirring, until the cheese melts and the soup is piping hot. Do not allow to boil.

3 Taste and adjust the seasoning, then ladle into warm, shallow soup bowls, adding a dollop of crème fraîche to each. Cut the reserved chive stalks in half and gently lay them, slightly crossed, on top.